How to Start a Startup: Final Assessment

Course: How to Start a Startup (Spring 2026)

Instructor: Fabiano Abreu Ott

Student Name: Jean-Luc Andre

Project Name: Mango Lab

Instructions

1. Make a copy of this document.
2. **Complete your document:** Please answer all of the following questions directly within this document. Be thoughtful and concise in your responses.
3. **Export your document as a PDF file.**
4. **Prepare your artifacts:** In a separate folder, gather all the other required submission files (e.g., your Pitch Deck PDF, your Business Model Canvas PDF, etc.).
5. **Create a ZIP File:** Create a single ZIP file containing this completed document (saved as a PDF) and your folder of artifacts.
6. **Submit your ZIP File via [this Google Form]**

Part 1: The Founder's Mindset

This section focuses on you, your motivations, and your personal definition of entrepreneurship.

1. How do you see yourself?
(Mark only one)

* [x] I am an entrepreneur

* [ ] I am curious about entrepreneurship

* [ ] I want to be an entrepreneur

* [ ] Other:

2. What is your "Why" in entrepreneurship?
Why are you / would you want to be an entrepreneur (or not)?

I read this book some while ago, and I believe it defined what I have always wanted entrepreneurship to be. Apart from being a lifestyle and it having a big risk of either being an entrepreneur that pushes innovation or wants to be the future unicorn, I more see it as a tool that enables me to have a lifestyle of freedom in space, time, and hopefully financially. *"In fact, entrepreneurship has always been the sole path to sovereignty. You simply cannot live your own life if you are required to submit to someone else's desires for where you ought to be, what you work on, the clothes you wear, your schedule, your projects, who you collaborate with, and how you spend your time."*

> — **Jay Topp**, *Drop Out & Travel*

And there's also this complementary line from the same chapter:

> *"Entrepreneurs have the greatest chance of being empowered, sovereign, and free individuals who live their lives with purpose."*

Apart from this I can practice entrepreneurship in any field I love, making this a life vocation and giving me the liberty to live free and do what I want with my life.

3. What is your personal definition of entrepreneurship?
Be very specific and reflect on your reasons for including / excluding elements in the definition.

Dictionary

Definitions from Oxford Languages · Learn more

entrepreneurship

/ˌɒntrəprəˈnəːʃɪp/

noun

the activity of setting up a business or businesses, taking on financial risks in the hope of profit.

"the new business opportunities have encouraged entrepreneurship on a grand scale"

I partly agree with this definition, but I would like to add to the definition that part of creating profit is making that profit in the place where you would like. To expand or explain in different words, for me, practicing entrepreneurship is not only to make profit of hope for it but is the ability to see the window of opportunity or the place where that business can be set up.

Part 2: The Venture

This section dives into the specifics of your project, your market, and your core business model.

4. Which type of project are you using for this assessment?
(Mark all that apply)

* [x] CODE project

* [ ] Work project

* [ ] Own company

* [ ] Case study

* [ ] Other:

5. Describe your project for this assessment.

Mango Labs (mango-lab.de) is my Berlin-based creative studio. Me and my technical co-founder Alberto help small businesses get quality ad creatives and design assets without the overhead of a full agency. We use an AI-assisted stack including Midjourney, Flux, Remotion, and Figma to pump out everything from Instagram Stories and Twitch panels to animated video ads and full brand systems. We're currently working with Bet & Babes and meetDWIGHT, with Luma Code coming up next. Long term, the freelance side is the foundation for a SaaS tool that replaces whole marketing teams with AI.

6. What is special about this project? Why is there still room for it in the market?
Most SMBs are stuck choosing between two options that don't really work for them. DIY tools like AdCreative.ai or Canva are cheap and fast but there's no creative thinking involved. Full-service agencies have the thinking but charge $5K a month minimum, which rules out most small businesses before anything gets started.
The tools also drop off after the creative. You get the assets and then you're on your own to figure out targeting, budgets, and what to actually do with them.
We handle both sides. We build the creatives using Midjourney, Flux, and Remotion with a creative director in the loop, and we manage the Meta side too, running and scaling the ads directly inside the account. One setup, one team, and someone actually paying attention to what's working.
Other studios like Uplan and Marketer offer something in that direction, but they're priced like agencies and mostly focused on brand awareness. We're cheaper and we care about one thing: whether the ads are actually driving conversions. Reach that doesn't turn into revenue isn't the goal.
That's the position we're in. AI-quality creative, Meta distribution, performance focus, at a price point small businesses can work with. And everything we learn running client campaigns feeds directly into Still, the product we're building on top of it.

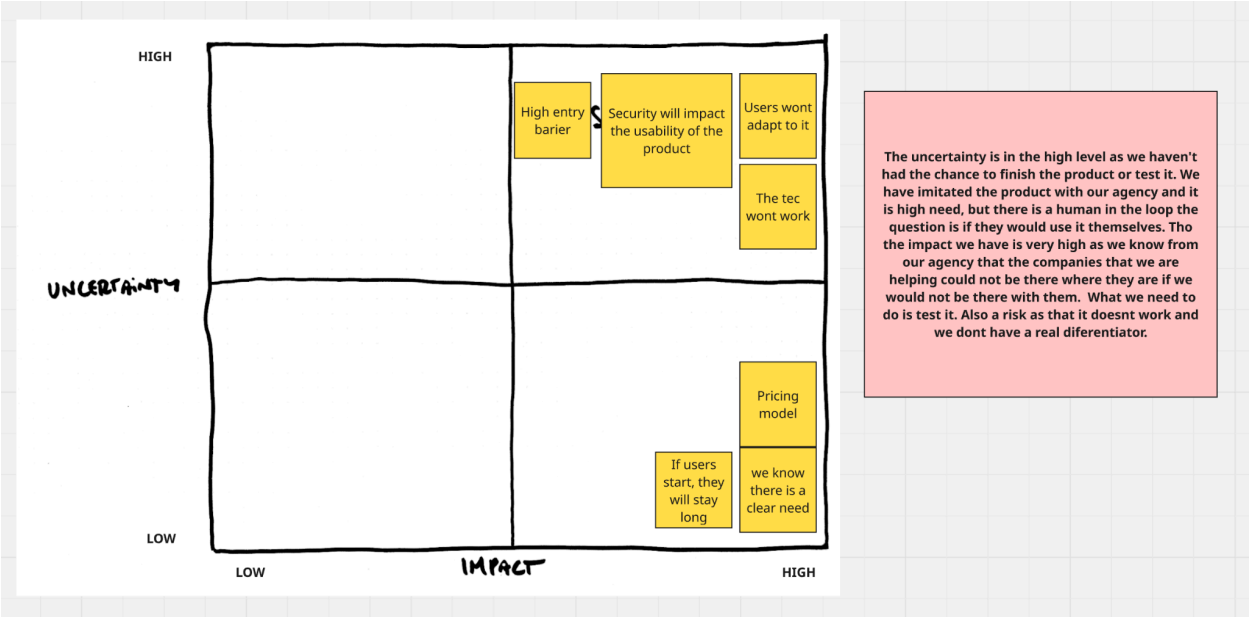
7. Describe your first "Traction Test".

We ran a 14-day validation sprint to find the problem, talk to people, and confirm demand. It worked. But in hindsight, we could have compressed that into one week by skipping the outreach phase and going straight to paid traffic against a landing page. That's what we're doing now.

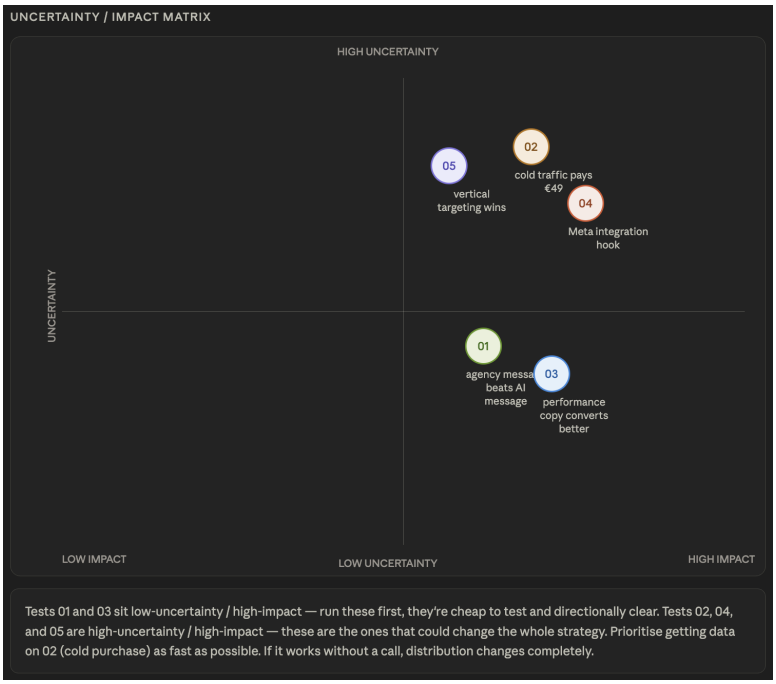
The MVP is live. Meta ads are running. Here's what we're actually testing.

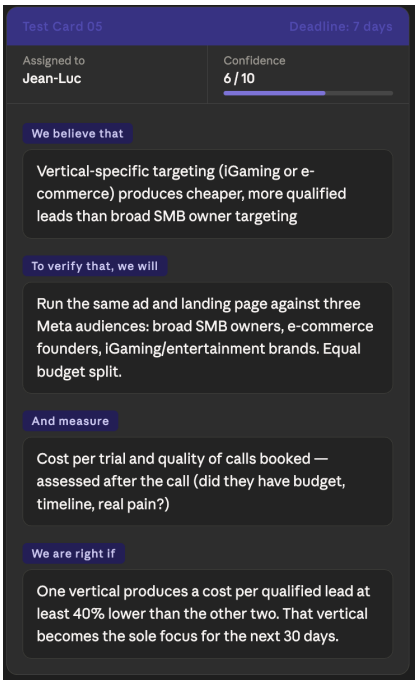
[(validation plan v3 document)]

To create this validation plan we created a risk matrix with our hypothesis of what was going to work and our confidence level in it. Apart from this we also made a full graph on how high an impact it would be if it would not work in our business and our uncertainty about it. This helped us analyze what were the actual risks, what we were not taking into consideration, and what we should. We made certain decisions across this map and matrix that we built from shaping the tests and also the product itself



After this we created hypotheses of what we believed was working or not and what we really thought was going to work. Through the marketing class we got a budget for Meta ads and we decided to run all of these tests to verify our hypotheses and claims. Through Meta ads and landing page variations, attached are the following screenshots of our hypothesis and another risk matrix. This is a Wizard-of-Oz test from Disciplined Entrepreneurship.





Test Card 01 — Deadline: 7 days

Assigned to: Jean-Luc
Confidence: 7 / 10

We believe that
SMBs respond more to "agency quality at freelancer speed" than to "AI-generated ad creatives" as a message

To verify that, we will
Run two Meta ad sets with identical targeting and budget. One leads with the AI angle, one with the results/agency angle. Same CTA, same landing page.

And measure
CTR and cost per landing page visit per ad set over 5 days

We are right if
The agency-angle ad achieves at least 30% lower CPC than the AI-angle ad

Test Card 02 — Deadline: 7 days

Assigned to: Jean-Luc
Confidence: 5 / 10

We believe that
A stranger who sees our Meta ad will pay €49 for a trial pack without needing a sales call first

To verify that, we will
Drive paid traffic directly to a landing page with one CTA: the €49 trial. No call required. Stripe checkout only.

And measure
Conversion rate from landing page visitor to paid trial. Track cost per acquisition.

We are right if
At least 2 out of 100 visitors pay the €49 trial within 7 days, without any manual follow-up

Test Card 03 — Deadline: 7 days

Assigned to: Jean-Luc
Confidence: 8 / 10

We believe that
SMBs care more about "ads that bring in customers" than "ads that look good" — performance copy converts better than creative copy

To verify that, we will
A/B test two landing page variants. Variant A headline: "Ad creatives that stop the scroll." Variant B: "Ad creatives that bring in customers." Same page otherwise.

And measure
Trial signups and CTA click rate per variant over 5 days of equal traffic

We are right if
Variant B generates at least 25% more CTA clicks or trial signups than Variant A

Test Card 04 — Deadline: 7 days

Assigned to: Jean-Luc
Confidence: 6 / 10

We believe that
Mentioning that we manage and scale Meta ads — not just design them — meaningfully increases conversion rate on the landing page

To verify that, we will
Add one line to half the landing page traffic: "We don't just make the ads. We run them." Split traffic 50/50 against version without it.

And measure
Signup and trial conversion rate per variant. Also track scroll depth to see if people engage with that line.

We are right if
The variant with the Meta line shows at least 20% higher conversion rate than the version without it

To test where Mango Labs actually stands, we put together five experiments that can run in a week using Meta ads and the MVP. Each one has a specific belief, a way to test it, something to measure, and a number that tells us if we were right. The matrix next to the cards shows which ones to run first. Tests 01 and 03 are the easiest to start with; two ad variations and a landing page headline swap, both readable within five days of spend. Tests 02, 04, and 05 are harder to call. They involve more unknowns, but the answers matter more. Test 02 is probably the most

important one in the batch: does someone who's never heard of Mango Labs pay €49 after seeing a Meta ad, without talking to anyone first? If yes, the whole sales process gets a lot simpler. If not, we need to fix the offer or the page before spending more on ads.

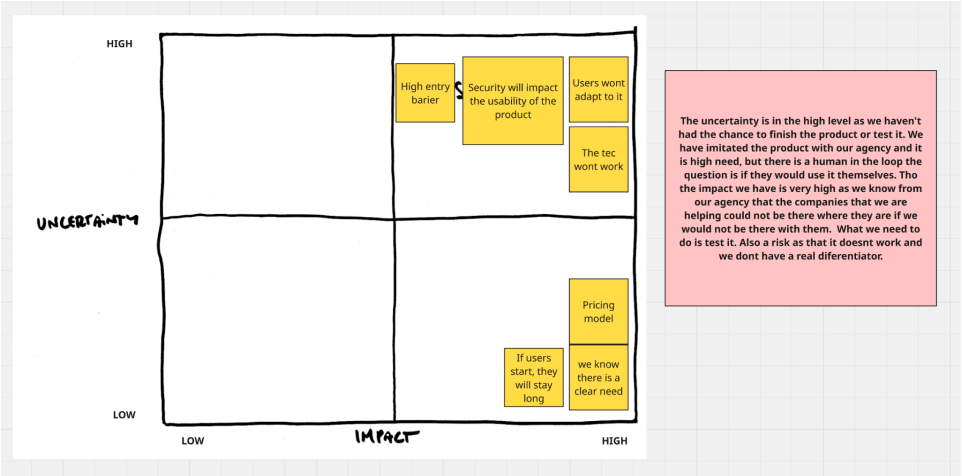
8. Describe your specific beachhead market. How did you find it, and why is it the best choice for your project?

The beachhead market is iGaming. Bet & Babes came through a referral, we delivered, and they came back. We didn't go looking for the vertical. It found us first.

Bet & Babes was an early-stage brand with no assets, no models, and no budget for a production shoot. Booking real talent before you know if the product works is hard to justify at that stage. AI visuals removed that problem. They got good-looking ad creatives without any of that cost.

Working with them also showed us something about the vertical more broadly. iGaming brands go through creative volume faster than most categories. Platforms push back on repetitive content, compliance limits what can be reused, and the look has to keep changing to stay effective. Most freelancers skip the space. Studios that work in it charge accordingly.

On top of that, most of these clients have had bad experiences with agencies. The agency runs the ads, then sends over a PDF at the end of the month. The client never actually sees inside the account. They don't know what ran, what worked, or what the money went to. With Mango Labs, the client has direct access to the Meta account throughout. They can check results whenever they want, follow along as things run, and ask questions in real time. For a brand still working out what resonates with their audience, that access is worth more than a polished report that shows up weeks later.



iGaming turned out to be a good place to start for all of these reasons. Strong creative demand, real budgets, a production cost problem that AI handles cheaply, and clients who have generally been kept out of the loop on their own campaigns. The next step is bringing the same setup to e-commerce and DTC brands, where the volume need is similar but the compliance side is much simpler.

9. Reflect on your Risk Ledger. How significant are the risks for your project, and what would you need to do to de-risk the project?

Here is the expanded risk matrix I mentioned in the validation sprint:

Risk 1: High entry barrier

Getting a small business to change how they handle ad creatives takes more than showing them a good product. There are existing habits, tools they already pay for, and people who have been doing things a certain way for a while. The agency model helps with this because clients don't have to adopt anything themselves at the start. They pay for the output and see what comes back. If they like the results, the conversation about the platform happens later on its own terms.

Risk 2: Security will impact usability

Giving clients direct access to a Meta ad account means working out permissions carefully. Too restricted and they can't see what they need. Too open and it creates problems around who controls what. A few more clients going through the process will show where the friction actually is, and that needs to happen before this gets offered to a lot of people at once.

Risk 3: Users won't adapt to the platform

Right now the agency does everything. The longer-term idea is that clients will want to run things themselves at some point. That hasn't been confirmed yet. A lot of SMB owners are stretched thin and picking up a new tool isn't always something they'll prioritise even if the tool is good. The traction tests running now will give a clearer picture. If clients keep coming back and start asking for more control, that's a sign the self-serve side is worth building out.

Risk 4: The tech won't work

Agency clients got real results, but someone was involved in reviewing and adjusting every output along the way. Whether the underlying tech holds up when a client runs it without that

support is still untested. This is the most pressing thing to find out before making any claims about how the product scales.

Risk 5: Pricing model

This one carries less uncertainty. The current pricing is working with early clients. The question is whether it holds as more people come through with different expectations and budgets. A clearer picture will come from a few more clients paying at different price points.

Risk 6: Retention and clear need

The agency already showed that clients who start tend to stick around, and the demand for fast, affordable ad creative is confirmed by the people who have already paid. These aren't things that need proving again. They're the foundation the rest of the business is being built on.

Overall

The product works and the need is there. The open question is whether clients will run it themselves without hand-holding. A lot of the other risks sit around that one. Once there's real data on it from the traction tests, most of the remaining decisions become a lot clearer.

Related Artifacts of this Section:

- TAM, SAM, SOM analysis https://drive.google.com/file/d/1mFYiBLf3bgnItg3yz5zGBfdgXsnjC2wQ/view?usp=sharing
- Business Model Canvas or Lean Canvas
- https://drive.google.com/file/d/1mNPxyINgK2RJGubYwwEuFIZRhJVdaWkg/view?usp=sharing
- Risk Ledger
- https://drive.google.com/file/d/1IBsmRDtxQ4-4d2sAznmjYdJWtf8Y8ozi/view?usp=sharing

Related Challenges:

[Template] Challenge 1/4 - How to Start a Startup
[Template] Challenge 3/4 - How to Start a Startup

Part 3: The Offering

This section focuses on your product, its defensibility, and its financial viability.

10. Six months from now, what will be the biggest problem for the project?

Six months from now, capacity is likely to be the main problem.

If the traction tests work and clients start coming in through Meta ads on top of referrals, Jean-Luc (me) becomes the bottleneck pretty fast. Right now every client brief, every creative decision, every delivery, and every Meta account goes through one person. That is manageable at the current volume. At ten or fifteen clients running at the same time, delivery starts slowing down and the quality of attention each client gets goes down with it. That is what the current pricing and positioning is built on, so it is also where the business starts to feel the strain first.

Alberto will be building Still during this period. That is where his time should go. But it means there is no one else on the agency side to absorb extra work when things get busy.

Underneath that is a pricing problem that makes the capacity issue worse. One-off project fees mean starting from scratch on revenue every month. Six months of that without moving anyone onto a retainer or recurring package means a lot of time goes into finding the next client rather than building on the ones already there. Bet & Babes and meetDWIGHT already trust the work. There is no structure yet to sell them more.

The third thing worth thinking about is what happens when Still is ready to launch. Migrating agency clients onto the platform is not automatic. Some will stick with the managed service because that is what they bought. Others might want to run it themselves. Working out how to handle that transition without losing people in the process is something that needs a plan before it arrives, not after.

We are aware this is the most likely pressure point for the business in the next six months and we are already moving on it.

Action plan

We are currently in conversations with salespeople to handle more of the client inflow. The goal is to take the business development and first-contact work off Jean-Luc (me) so that capacity goes toward delivery and account management rather than prospecting.

The bigger structural fix comes when the Still MVP is built. Right now producing a creative takes time, judgment, and manual steps. When Still is live, generating a creative becomes a single click. That changes the output capacity significantly. A workload that currently takes a full day can be handled in an hour. That means the same team can serve double the clients without adding headcount, and the agency model starts to scale in a way it currently cannot.

The sequence we are working toward is: salespeople handle inbound while Jean-Luc (me) focuses on delivery and quality, Alberto ships the Still MVP, and once the platform is running, client work moves through it rather than through manual production. The bottleneck does not disappear overnight but each of these steps reduces it before it becomes critical.

11. How might people with different cultural backgrounds perceive your offering?
Name at least two specific hurdles that might stop them from adopting your product and how you might overcome them.

Mango Labs is already working across cultures without having planned for it. The client list covers iGaming, a learning platform, a clothing manufacturer, and an SMB in Costa Rica, all through referrals. That mix shows the product can travel across markets, but it also points to two friction points worth addressing.

Hurdle 1: AI visuals read differently depending on the market

In Western markets, AI-generated creative is becoming fairly standard in advertising. In Latin America and more traditional industries, a real photo shoot still tends to signal professionalism in a way that AI output does not, even when the quality is good. The perceived effort behind the work matters to those clients as much as the result. The way to handle this is to show the work before talking about how it was made. The Bet & Babes client did not know the assets were AI-generated and was happy with them. Starting with results and explaining the process later tends to work better than leading with the tech.

Hurdle 2: The product is built around Meta, and not every client lives there

The full offering, creatives plus Meta account management, makes most sense for clients who are already running Meta ads. For a B2B client like the learning platform, LinkedIn is more relevant. For brands targeting younger audiences, TikTok matters more. A client who does not use Meta does not get much from the management side, which is one of the stronger parts of the pitch. For now the answer is being upfront about who the product fits best. Further down the road, adding more platform integrations to Still would open this up.

One broader point worth noting: in Latin American markets, business tends to move through personal relationships before it turns commercial. The referral channel that brought in all the current clients actually suits that dynamic. The risk is that cold Meta ads may behave quite differently in those markets compared to Germany, and it would be worth tracking traction test results by geography to see if that shows up in the data.

12. What is your moat / defensibility of your value proposition?
Still combines AI visual production, Meta ad distribution, and full account transparency in one tool at SMB pricing. No other product in the market currently does all three together at this price point. The positioning is backed by real client validation through the agency, which means the workflows and creative systems behind it have already been tested on paying clients across multiple verticals. And because every campaign that runs through it feeds back into the system, the output gets better over time without the cost going up.

13. How are you using innovation (business, social, design, tech) as a moat or competitive advantage?

The innovation is not in any single tool but in how they are combined. Using Midjourney, Flux, Remotion, Claude and a plethora of vibe coding, together with a human creative director and direct Meta integration produces an output pipeline that no individual SaaS tool or traditional agency can match at this price point.

Related Artifacts of this Section:

- Unit Economics Sketch
- still_unit_economics.xlsx
- Still — LTV & Pricing Model.pdf claude made it pretty
- Pitch Deck
- Mango Lab Pitch Deck.pdf

Related Challenges: [Template] Challenge 2/4 - How to Start a Startup

Part 4: The Journey & Reflection

This final section is for reflecting on your process and learnings throughout the course.

Related Challenges: [Template] Challenge 4/4 - How to Start a Startup

14. Reflecting on the entrepreneurial stories of other founders that were presenting in the class, which specific lesson or mistake resonates most with your project right now, and why?

The story that resonates most with me right now is David's brother. He and his team built their entire prototype and MVP first, and then ran into the wall everyone warns you about. They couldn't sell it and it didn’t work. The reframe came when he started selling before building. He just ran ads, took payment, then figured out how to deliver (he told us to refund if it doesn’t work). That insight changed how I think about the order of operations for Mango Lab.

What got me was when David went deeper. Some of his friends had already hired software engineers, paid them for months, and still hadn't sold a single seat. I sat with that for a minute and realised we're closer to that pattern than I'd been willing to admit. Alberto and I have been building Still for two months. The only money the platform has earned is money the agency made for it. The platform itself hasn't been tested by a single cold buyer.

The action I took from that lesson is the campaign that's running right now. ENGINE_001 is €400 of Meta ads pointed at SMBs, asking them to pay €49 for a trial of a product the agency can deliver manually behind the scenes. If the ads convert, the platform thesis survives. If they don't, no amount of additional engineering on Still is going to fix what the market hasn't asked for. We already had the traction test cards from earlier in the semester telling us the offer

worked under controlled conditions. The ads test whether the offer survives contact with cold strangers, which is the real validation we need before we spend another month writing code that nobody asked for.

15. Reflect on the question of scaling.
Why would you / would you not want to scale this project up? Would you want external funding for it? What might be the upsides and downsides of bootstrapping?

I want to scale Mango Lab because the pain we are solving shows up the same way everywhere we look. SMBs spending five to fifty thousand euros a month on ads, whether they are in iGaming, e-commerce, DTC or adjacent verticals, all face the same gap. Agency-quality output is priced for enterprise. DIY tools like AdCreative.ai or Canva produce work without strategy, we tried some of them and they are complicated and not easy to use. The middle is empty. Still sits in the affordable and fully automated quadrant of the competitive matrix, and that quadrant currently has no incumbent. If we do not scale into it, someone else will.

The unit economics support scaling on top of the strategic case. Blended LTV is €2,600 against a €49 CAC. That is a 53:1 ratio, well past the 3:1 minimum from Disciplined Entrepreneurship Step 17. Gross margin is 75%-89%. Net profit at 100 subscribers is already €3,013 a month at 23% margin. Every additional Still subscriber also compounds the data the platform learns from, which makes the next subscriber's results better. That kind of curve rewards going faster.

On funding: I would take external capital, but only after we have hit the milestones that turn the round into a calculated bet. The trigger conditions: paid-trial conversion rate stable above 2%, the first 50 paying subscribers retained past month 3, and clear evidence that one vertical, iGaming or e-commerce, has been won at scale. With those numbers, a seed round becomes about pouring fuel on a fire we can already point to. Without them, capital arrives before we know what to do with it. That is the version of this story that ends with runway burned on a polished product nobody asked for.

On bootstrapping (where we are now):

Upsides: Every hour we work is paid for by client revenue, which forces discipline on what we build next. Pricing decisions have to survive contact with people who will actually pay. Co-founders keep equity (biggest thing about getting funding). We get to build the product the validation demands rather than the product the deck slide demands.

Downsides: Speed is bounded by the calendar. We are competing against funded players like AdCreative, Superside and Madgicx who can outspend us on ads and engineering. The market window we are aiming at, the convergence of AI creative quality, open campaign APIs and SMB ad budgets at all-time highs, will not stay open forever. If it closes faster than we expected, bootstrapping costs us position.

The plan is to bootstrap until the metrics earn the round, then raise to scale into the verticals the agency has already validated.

16. Reflect on your personal "non-negotiables".
Building a hyper-growth "unicorn" often requires a lot of personal sacrifice (time, hobbies, relationships), while building a sustainable "lifestyle" business might offer more balance but less scale. Be honest with yourself: what specific things in your life are you truly willing to give up for your venture, and what will you protect at all costs? If you're not actually planning to found a Startup yourself, you can answer this question regarding your career path in general. So: what specific things in your life are you truly willing to give up for your professional career, and what will you protect at all costs?

I learned what this question actually means before I learned what a startup was. I trained Taekwondo seriously for years and competed nationally in Muay Thai in Costa Rica. The lesson the sport taught me, more than any technique, is that balance is not a permanent state. You go out of balance on purpose for a stretch, a fight camp or a season, knowing the imbalance is the cost of the next level. Then you come back. The hard part is being honest about what you're trading and for how long, and being even more honest about the things you cannot trade without losing yourself.

What I am willing to give up:

- **Predictable income.** I chose agency cash flow over the salaried-job path. The trade is locked in until Still hits €10K MRR.
- **Most of my evenings and weekends for the next 24 months.** The window for Still to take its quadrant is short, and the work to get there doesn't fit inside a 9–5.
- **A lot of small consumption habits.** New gear, eating out, most travel plans. All off the table while every euro is more useful inside the business than out of it.
- **The comfort of being the person responsible.** Sales, delivery, hiring, payroll, missed deadlines, refunded clients. All of it lands on me. I'm choosing that.
- **The sport itself, for now.** I'm not training competitively right now, and I'm not going to be for a while. Taekwondo and Muay Thai made me the person who can sit through what this venture demands. That's the gift the sport gave me. The trade-off is that I can't keep practicing at the level I want while the business is also asking for everything. When Still is running on its own engine, I come back to the gym.
- **Some of my physical health, on the margins.** Sleep dropping below my preferred eight hours. Meals that aren't planned. The session I skipped this morning because the week broke. The hard floor stays in place. The perfectionist version is on hold.
- **The version of myself that has never lied to a client.** This is the one that costs me most to write down. I built the agency on the rule of no overpromises and no work I wouldn't sign my name to. The Wizard-of-Oz test we are running right now bends that rule. Clients are paying €499 for what they think is an automated platform. The platform exists, but most of the work behind it is me and Alberto in a room. They get the result

they paid for, but the mechanism is not what they think it is. I am going to keep doing this until Still catches up to its own promise, and I am owning that this is the trade. The protection on top of it is that we will not let the gap become a fraud. The moment a client asks how it actually works, we tell them the truth.

What I will protect, no matter what:

- **A floor under my physical health.** Sleep enough to think clearly, movement enough that the body keeps working, and food that is not made of coffee. The flex above the floor lives in the give-up list. The floor itself is non-negotiable, because every problem feels harder on five hours of sleep.
- **The relationships that keep me sane.** Family, the people closest to me. I will protect time with them as a deliberate calendar item. The default is they get scheduled first, not last.
- **The truth when a client asks for it.** This is the line under the integrity trade-off above. We will run the Wizard-of-Oz pattern. We will not deny it when asked directly. That is the difference between a validation tactic and a lie.
- **My partnership with Alberto.** Co-founder breakdowns kill more startups than competitors do. The 3-day check-in cadence we wrote into the validation plan is not optional. It's how the company stays insulated from the friction every co-founder partnership produces(this we saw in class with Andre).

17. Which legal entity would you form / have you formed, and why?
If you are working with an existing business, which alternative legal structure could be interesting, and why?

Mango Lab is operating informally right now. We're keeping it that way until the validation work earns the cost of incorporation. The plan: register a UG (haftungsbeschränkt) in Germany in the next 60 days, then convert to a GmbH once we've built up the €25,000 reserve the conversion requires. The UG bridges that gap. We can start with €1 of share capital and grow into the threshold through the 25% retained-earnings rule, which is more useful than parking €25K in a share account from day one.

Two reasons we're incorporating. The first is liability. Mango Lab runs paid ads inside client Meta accounts and handles creative IP, including AI-generated work where copyright is genuinely grey. Any client dispute or platform ban currently lands on me personally, and Still will need the corporate veil before it scales. The second is Alberto. He's in Germany on a visa and his work authorization isn't fully sorted yet. Holding shares in a company is not the same as being employed by one under German immigration rules, so a UG with both of us as shareholders gives him a clean way to be a co-founder while his work permit catches up.

Berlin is the registered seat. It's where Alberto and I both live and work. German tax law is well-understood by the people we'd hire from, and a German VAT ID simplifies EU B2B invoicing through the reverse-charge mechanism.

Founder split: 50/50 between me (sales, delivery) and Alberto (product, tech). We're going to discuss vesting properly after this class. Current thinking is to add a 1-year vesting clause once we incorporate. We trust each other. The clause is there for when someone outside the two of us starts looking at the cap table, like a future hire or investor.

18. Beyond this course, what is the single most important thing you need to learn, or the most important person you need to talk to in Berlin, to move forward? How will you find that information or get that meeting?

Right now there is one blocker that sits in front of everything else: opening the Berlin market for the agency layer that funds Still. We have validated the offer in the UK, but Berlin is where Mango Lab actually operates and where the next ten clients need to come from. It is not enough to call Berlin an opened market.

The single most important person I need to talk to in Berlin is another agency owner who is already running paid acquisition for SMB clients in DACH. Someone who could become a customer for the agency layer in the short term, and an early adopter for the Still platform once it is self-serve. That conversation does two things at once. It opens a real Berlin sales channel. It also gives us a second pair of eyes to harden the platform against the kinds of campaigns it is actually going to run in this market.

How I get the meeting:

1. **Cold LinkedIn outreach with a real opening.** The pitch is short and direct. Mango Lab is a Berlin-based ad-creative agency working with SMBs across iGaming, e-commerce and adjacent verticals. We have an unusual platform layer behind the agency. I want twenty minutes of your time on what is actually working in DACH right now. Founders answer questions about the work they are proud of. They ignore vague "let's connect" requests. We already tried this in the validation plan and it kind of worked. We got some connects but not as many replies so I don't really believe in this one but at least we're gonna try again.

2. **Warm intros earned from those cold messages.** If the first conversation lands, I close it by asking which of their network would be the best second conversation. Cold to warm is the cheapest network compounding move there is. Or if not, find these people at CODE or somebody who knows them.

3. **Berlin in person.** Factory Berlin, Merantix, Founders Pulse, the agency-owner roundtables in Mitte. The right person is in a room within walking distance every other week. The cost of showing up is one evening.

The deadline I am setting myself for landing the first three Berlin agency-owner meetings is end of June 2026.

19. Reflect on your journey in learning about how to start a startup. How have your expectations changed, what will you do differently in the future?

What I expected coming into this course was a stack of methods to apply: Lean Canvas, the Mom Test, Disciplined Entrepreneurship's 24 steps, Y Combinator's playbook. I assumed founding would feel like applying those tools correctly and the answers would follow. The lesson the course actually taught me is that those tools are scaffolding. They help you ask the right questions. They cannot tell you whether your answer is true. The only thing that does that is putting the answer in front of someone with a wallet.

The clearest version of that lesson came from the Wizard-of-Oz test we ran with the gambling brand client. We had been spinning on Still's product positioning, asking ourselves whether it was a creative tool or a measurement tool, an AI ad maker or a media buyer. Then a paying client used the agency's manual workflow, did not realise it was AI behind the curtain, paid €500, and asked when we could do another batch. That single transaction collapsed weeks of positioning debate. Everything we have written since, including the v3 validation plan, the agency-first decision, the move to €49 paid trials over free ones, comes from internalising that one signal, that before this course I would have never noticed because I would just say, "Oh it's a small little client that does not mean anything.".

The deeper change the class made in me is harder to put into a single sentence. Coming in, my default was to build something and then think about how to sell it. The class kept pushing me to invert that. Sell first, build the rest after the buyer has paid. And not as a theoretical principle. As the actual question to ask on a Tuesday: are you talking to a customer this week, or are you polishing a prototype this week? When the answer was honest, it was almost always the second one. ENGINE_001 exists because that question got asked enough times that I could not avoid the answer.

The other thing the course did was confirm a lot of the work I had already started. The pitch deck, the BMC, the risk ledger, the unit economics, the validation plan, the traction test cards were all in motion when I started the class. What changed is how I value the early clients we already have. The two paying gambling brands and the friends who tested first drafts of the offer are how the business proves it exists. The course taught me to treat them as the ground I build from.

What I would do differently next time:

- **Start selling sooner.** We had something worth charging for at week three, but I waited until I felt ready, which meant adding polish nobody asked for. Selling earlier would have surfaced the same insights weeks faster.

- **Write the validation plan before writing the deck.** I wrote a pitch deck before the v3 validation plan. The deck told a story I wanted to be true. The plan was the version of that story stress-tested against what actually had to work. The order should have been reversed.
- **Don't treat course materials as the curriculum.** The most useful inputs in this assessment came from outside the syllabus. Hormozi's $100M Offers gave me the decoy trial structure. The Mom Test taught me how to run a customer call without leading the witness. Lenny Rachitsky's newsletter has the line about not settling for meh reactions, which I keep coming back to. The class gave me the vocabulary. The actual learning happened outside the syllabus, in conversations with operators who had run the play before that was very useful because they were brought inside the class and later I found them in action stepping outside of the class.

What I am taking forward from this module long after the assessment is graded: agency-first as a validation principle, the €49 decoy offer as a way to filter buyers, the 3-day co-founder check-in, and the discipline of reviewing the conversation log before changing direction. And the bigger one underneath all of it: early clients, even the friends-of-friends and the small ones, are the proof the business is real. They built everything else.

20. How have you used generative AI in the process of this practice assessment?
List all features you used and what you used them for.

I used generative AI throughout this assessment. The list:

- **Claude (Anthropic), conversational drafting via Claude.ai web and Cowork mode.** This was the main tool. I used it to structure the assessment document, draft and pressure-test answers to the reflection questions in Parts 2 to 4, refine the "Why" answer in Q2. Claude also read across the supporting artifacts and made them prettier to show here in the document. But after discussing with him I came here. We wrote everything that we discussed. I also used it for challenge number four to write the descriptions of each person and for the synthetic interview.
- **ChatGPT / GPT-4-class models.** Brainstorming campaign hooks for the Meta Ads creatives that sit inside the PM_23 ENGINE_001 brief, and quick-checking pricing logic against Disciplined Entrepreneurship Step 17 conventions.
- **Midjourney, Flux, Nano Banana 2.** Ad-creative image generation. Used inside Mango Lab's actual production pipeline (which is the project this assessment is about) and reused for the visual mockups in the ENGINE_001 creative brief.
- **Remotion.** Programmatic video rendering for the Reel creative variants in the ENGINE_001 brief.
- **Wispr Flow.** I don't really know if this counts as AI but I now speak more than I type. Almost all of this document was written using Wispr Flow, which is just a transcription tool, so it is exactly what I say written. It really doesn't use AI but I am just putting it here for the doubts.

All reflective answers in this document are my views. AI helped me phrase them more clearly and cleaned the writing. Where AI suggested a framing I disagreed with, I rewrote it.

21. I herewith certify that the statement on the use of generative AI is correct and complete and that the content of my practice assessment is my own original work.
* [x] Yes

Challenges: Description

Throughout the semester you will receive 4 challenges. Each challenge is related to specific topics within the How to Start a Startup course. Each challenge includes a set of prompts to answer after completing it. You decide when to complete each challenge.

[Template] Challenge 1/4 - How to Start a Startup

1. **Who did you talk to and why did they fit your chosen beachhead market? (Be specific about their characteristics).**

We talked to Fatema, the marketing coordinator at CODE University. Small team of five people doing everything, organic content, event coverage, website maintenance, merchandise ordering, and now with the one person who handled half of that leaving, she is taking all of it on herself. No dedicated designer. No proper equipment. They borrow a camera from someone else. She fits the beachhead market because she is exactly the kind of person we are building for: a small organisation trying to punch above their weight with almost no resources, where the marketer is doing five different jobs at once and none of them particularly well because there is just not enough time. The problem is not that she lacks skill. She knows what good looks like. She just cannot get there with what she has.

2. **What was the most surprising or counter-intuitive thing you learned during your conversation? (Share a specific story or direct quote).**

I expected her to tell me that creating content was the hard part. She does not even do ads. That whole side is two other people's job. Her biggest daily task is posting stories. That is it. The most basic, repetitive thing in the job is the one that drains her most because it never stops. She also told us she found out about a cultural evening the morning it was happening. That was the actual reason she described herself as overworked, not the volume of work but the total lack of planning. Things just appear. You show up and something new is on the list. The quote that really hit me was almost at the end: "people use ChatGPT for marketing anyways, so why not have an app for that exact purpose?" She said it casually, like it was obvious. We were trying to sell her on the idea and she basically sold it back to us herself.

3. **Did this conversation validate or invalidate your core assumption about the problem? How has your confidence in this problem area changed?**

Validated in a general sense, but we were wrong about where the pain actually sits. Our assumption going in was that ad creation was the hard part, that people were spending hours making something that did not perform. For her, ads are someone else's problem entirely. Her pain is organic content, daily stories, event coverage alone with no equipment. There is a 40-second video she filmed last Monday that still is not posted because Marcel is the only one who edits and he is backed up. So the core assumption held, content ops is genuinely painful

and time-consuming, but the specific job we thought we were solving is not the one she needs solved. That shifted my confidence. I am more confident the problem is real. I am less confident we know exactly which version of the problem to go after first.

4. **Based on this single conversation, what is the next question you need to answer? What is the next experiment or conversation you need to have to de-risk your idea further?**

We need to talk to someone who is actually running the ads. In her team that is two other people we did not speak to. But more than that, we need to talk to an SMB owner who is doing all of this alone with no team. She has backup. Someone else handles the ads, someone else does the editing, there is a weekly meeting where tasks get divided. The person we actually need to reach is the one who is also the performance marketer, also the content creator, also the founder, all at once. What does that person's Monday morning look like when they have no Marcel to hand the video to? That is the next conversation and that is why I did the following.

PM_16 — Challenge 1 Supplementary Research: Synthetic Customer Interview

[Template] Challenge 2/4 - How to Start a Startup

1. **Shortly describe the setting and the audience for your pitch. (e.g., In-class presentation, friendly practice session, formal pitch event).**
    a. The pitch was at Better Products, which is this event the module runs where you actually go up and pitch to a real audience. Stage, timer, five minutes to present and then questions from a panel. The room was students and faculty but also people from outside. One of the students in the audience was a marketing director from an actual company (get your guide).
2. **Reflect on giving this pitch. What did you learn from the audience's reactions? (Which parts of your pitch created the most energy or confusion? What did their body language tell you?).**
    b. I opened with a story about a friend who runs a bakery. She is a real person, the problem is real. In earlier practice runs I was leading with data, like "70% of SMBs struggle with social media," and nobody moved. The moment I put a specific person on slide one, a specific Monday morning, the marketing director on the audience leaned in. I could actually see it happen. The rest of the room kind of followed. The slides I had stripped down to one idea per frame also held people in a way the older decks did not. I think I had something like fourteen slides before, a lot of them with five bullet points each. You could see people go somewhere else the second those came up. What I actually said about the friend was she paid an agency $2,000 and she only received a PDF document and two Instagram ads. She didn't even know they worked. This is what Mango Labs

changes... The marketing director leaned in and then asked a ton of questions. I hit a real spot in her pain. This was a real struggle that her product solved. After it she asked a ton of questions and all of them we could answer because we had researched this product on this specific pain. And based on all of her questions and explanations of a slide in a real story that kept the people engaged because in other presentations it did not

3. **Did you iterate your pitch after the experience? If yes, how? (What specific part of your story, a slide, or a key message did you change based on the feedback you received?).**
    c. After the first practice run I went back to Guy Kawasaki's stuff, the "problem first" principle. My original version spent slide two explaining what Mango Lab does before the audience even had a reason to care. I flipped it. Lead with the problem: SMB owners are invisible on social not because they do not try but because nobody gave them a playbook. Then the product actually makes sense when it shows up. I also cut the phrase "our platform" from every slide because it does nothing. Replaced it with a before-and-after: here is what Monday looks like without this, here is what it looks like with it. Deck went from fourteen slides to nine.
4. **What was the most challenging or insightful question you received from the audience? What does this question reveal about the biggest risk or the most compelling part of your venture?**
    d. The hardest question was "how are you actually going to get your first customers?" I kind of froze on it. The acquisition plan we had at the time was basically organic content and word of mouth, which only works once you already have something going. SMBs are genuinely hard to reach from zero. They are not reading industry newsletters, they are not showing up to startup events, the sales cycle is slow. I did not have a clean answer and I knew it. That question is more or less what pushed us to rethink the whole acquisition side in the sprint after. And something it had me reflecting later was that our acquisition price for an SMB that does not already have budget for ads is very high because if you're not running a budget for ads, it is not the only cost of our platform. It is the cost of our platform plus our ad spend. Right now we're actively trying to solve that with the decoy offer.

[Template] Challenge 3/4 - How to Start a Startup

1. **Who did you reach out to and what channel did you use? (e.g., "10 founders via LinkedIn," "10 students via email," "10 potential partners via a warm intro").**

    We did two things at the same time. The first was warm outreach, messages to friends asking if they knew anyone running paid ads for a business or an e-commerce brand. No pitch, just asking for a conversation. Something like "do you know anyone I could have a 15-minute chat with? I'm just trying to learn." The second was cold LinkedIn, split into two batches. Saturday we went after DTC founders, focused on creative fatigue. Sunday was e-commerce brand owners and freelance media buyers. Both batches used short

connection requests under 300 characters, referenced something specific from their profile or a recent post, then followed up with one question once they accepted: "last time you needed new ad creatives for a campaign, how did you handle it?" No product mention until they described a real problem. We also ran LinkedIn Premium throughout, which made a real difference in who we could reach.

2. **What was your response rate? (e.g., "I sent 10 messages and received 1 reply, a 10% response rate").**

   Roughly 25% across everything. Warm outreach came back fastest, which makes sense because there is a mutual contact behind the ask. Cold LinkedIn actually did better than I expected. The gap between a free account and Premium was real enough that I would not do another sprint without it. Three of the warm conversations turned into actual paying clients at the €40 trial tier. None of the cold outreach has closed yet but a few are still in conversation.

3. **Reflect on the responses (or lack of responses). What did this experiment tell you about your message or your value proposition?**

   A few things stood out. Warm outreach worked almost immediately because a friend vouching for you is a completely different thing from a cold message. The three clients we got all came through that channel, which tells me the product is real. But it is also a ceiling, and we hit it fast.

   On the cold side, Alberto's network did not respond to direct outreach but started coming back after we posted organic content on LinkedIn. They did not reply to the ask. They just appeared after seeing something. That tells me that audience wants to see the thing actually exist before they will talk.

   The messages that got replies were the ones that led with something specific from their profile or a recent post. Generic openers got ignored. And the follow-up that worked best was the Mom Test question about what they had done before, not anything about what we are building. People will talk about what they have already done. They are not going to evaluate something for someone they just met.

   25% on cold outreach is not a normal number. That told me the problem is real.

4. **Based on this single experiment, what is the #1 thing you will change in your outreach message or strategy before you contact your next 10 customers?**

The referral ask. At the end of every conversation, warm or cold, the next message should have been: "do you know anyone else who deals with slow creative turnaround or creative fatigue on Meta ads?" We did not do that consistently and we should have. Every person who described a real problem was basically a door to two or three more people with the same problem. We left that on the table. The next sprint is less about who else to message and more about treating the conversations we already have as a way into more.

[Template] Challenge 4/4 - How to Start a Startup

1. **Who did you reach out to, and why did you admire them?**

I started by making a proper list. Thirty-two people across different regions, different stages, different industries but all connected in some way to building products, growing brands, or figuring out how to sell. Some were in the DTC and performance marketing world directly because that is the space Mango Lab lives in. Some were founders I had been following for years just because I found them interesting. A few were from Costa Rica or Latin America, which mattered to me personally because I do not see that world represented much in the Berlin startup bubble.

From the US:
- Alex Hormozi — built a $100M+ business and documents everything publicly, no packaging around it, just what actually works
- Nik Sharma — runs Sharma Brands, the person most DTC founders call when their ads stop working
- Cody Plofker — CMO at Jones Road Beauty, posts openly about Meta ads results and creative testing in a way most marketing people would never do
- Nick Shackelford — Structured, one of the biggest names in Meta ads for DTC, has seen more creative tests than almost anyone
- Taylor Holiday — Common Thread Collective, writes honestly about what e-commerce growth actually looks like versus what people claim
- Noah Kagan — AppSumo, his stories about getting the first customer are some of the most useful things I have read
- Gary Vaynerchuk — built Wine Library through content before anyone was doing it, never stopped since
- Sahil Lavingia — Gumroad, wrote publicly about not becoming a unicorn and finding meaning in building something smaller anyway
- Moiz Ali — Native, built a DTC brand from scratch and sold it to P&G, knows the full arc from zero to exit
- Andrew Wilkinson — Tiny, thinks about building companies completely differently from the standard playbook
- Rand Fishkin — SparkToro, honest and contrarian takes on marketing that most people in the industry do not want to hear

From Europe:

- Harry Dry — Marketing Examples, Brighton, studies what actually makes marketing work not what theoretically should
- Florian Heinemann — Project A Ventures, Berlin, one of the few VCs who genuinely understands performance marketing instead of just funding it
- Niklas Jansen — Blinkist co-founder, built a real consumer product out of Berlin when people said you could not do that from here
- Christoph Janz — Point Nine Capital, Berlin, writes publicly about SaaS metrics in a way that actually teaches you something
- Lea-Sophie Cramer — Amorelie, built a brand in a taboo category and made it mainstream in Germany
- Daniel Ek — Spotify, built something global from Stockholm before European startups were taken seriously by anyone
- Hanno Renner — Personio, scaled enterprise HR software from Munich, took the hard market and won
- Pieter Levels — Levels.io, Dutch, builds profitable solo internet businesses and shares the numbers openly while everyone else hides them
- Sophia Bendz — early at Spotify, now at Atomico, has seen both the building side and the investing side of European tech

From Latin America:
- Simón Borrero — Rappi co-founder, Colombia, built one of the most ambitious delivery startups in LATAM from nothing
- Henrique Dubugras — Brex co-founder, came from Brazil and built a fintech unicorn in Silicon Valley at 21, the age I am now
- Pedro Franceschi — Brex co-founder, same story, same age, same level of ambition
- Sebastián Mejía — Rappi co-founder, Colombia, another person who looked at the LATAM market and decided to go all in
- Wences Casares — Xapo, Argentine, was building crypto infrastructure years before it was mainstream and took the heat for it
- Martin Varsavsky — serial entrepreneur from Argentina, multiple companies across multiple decades, still building
- Paula Bellizia — president of Google LATAM and then Microsoft, has built brand and commercial strategy across a region most companies treat as an afterthought

From Costa Rica:
- Luis Monge Malo — digital marketing and CRO, one of the most credible marketing voices in the Spanish-speaking world, built a real reputation without ever leaving the country
- Randall Piedra — entrepreneur and investor from San José, one of the few people in Costa Rica actively building the local startup ecosystem
- Two more founders from the local tech community in San José who I had seen speaking at events and found on LinkedIn

For 20 of them I used a GPT prompt to generate a personalised first message. I fed it their profile, a recent post, and a specific question I actually wanted answered. For the other 12 I

wrote the messages manually. I got a few replies. Most of them said something like "I would love to but things are crazy right now, circle back in a month." A few did not reply at all. In the end the conversation that actually happened was with my dad. He has been running his own business my whole life and the whole time I was building Mango Lab I had not really sat down and asked him how he thinks about selling. So I did. That ended up being the best conversation I had.

2. **What was the most valuable or surprising piece of advice you received during your chat? (Share a specific story or direct quote).**

2. I kept waiting for something more complicated and instead he basically said: "the first person who pays you is not buying the product. They are buying you. They are betting on you as a person." He told me about the early years of his business, when he had no brand and no track record and the only thing he could put on the table was himself. He would show up early, remember details about the client, call back the same day. Not because he had a system but because he genuinely did not want to let people down. He said at some point you stop needing to pitch because the people around you already know how you work and they refer you. That stayed with me. We had been so focused on the product and the acquisition side and the messaging, and my dad described the first sale as a personal bet, not a product decision.

3. **Reflect on the outreach process. What did you learn about crafting a message that gets a reply from a busy, successful person?**

3. The automation taught me something. For the 20 messages I ran through GPT, I fed it the profile, a recent post, and the specific question I wanted to ask. The output was actually decent. Most of those messages read as personalised because the inputs were personalised. But there is a ceiling. The ones that went nowhere were the ones where the question was still generic even after the personalisation, something I had reverse-engineered from their profile rather than something I had actually thought about. The manual messages were slower but the ones that got replies were the ones where I had a genuinely specific reason to reach out. The learning is that personalisation is the floor. You can automate the floor. You cannot automate the part where you actually have something interesting to say. And the best conversation I had came from the person closest to me, which tells me I had been underestimating who was already in my network.

Required Artifacts: Description

Please create a folder named "artifacts" and include the following files. Ensure each file is a 1-page PDF where possible.

1. **TAM/SAM/SOM Analysis (PDF):** A one-page document that provides a quantitative estimate of your market size. It should clearly define your Total Addressable Market (TAM), Serviceable Available Market (SAM), and Serviceable Obtainable Market (SOM), with sources or clear assumptions for your numbers.
2. **Business Model / Lean Canvas (PDF):** A one-page visual chart that lays out the core components of your business model. Use a standard template like the Business Model Canvas or Lean Canvas.
3. **Risk Ledger (PDF):** A one-page document that lists the top 5-7 most critical risks to your project. For each risk, briefly describe it and suggest a potential mitigation strategy.
4. **Unit Economics Sketch (PDF):** A one-page export of a spreadsheet that breaks down the revenues and costs associated with one "unit" of your business (e.g., one customer, one subscription, one product sold).
5. **Pitch Deck (PDF):** Your final pitch deck should tell a compelling story of the problem, your solution, your market, and your team.

A note on the two extras I added

The standard ask was five artifacts, I added two more because honestly the document on its own felt kind of incomplete to me. The main paper has all the moves in it, but a lot of the reasoning behind why we did what we did kind of gets lost in the prose, and I wanted to fix that.

The Framework Application Map (Artifact 6)

A single page where the four frameworks that shaped Mango Lab sit next to the actual moves they shaped. Why we charged €49 instead of giving the trial away for free. Why Bet & Babes was our first client and not someone we cold-pitched. Why we ran paid META ads before there was even a product to sell. Lean Startup, Disciplined Entrepreneurship, Y Combinator, and the Mom Test. Theory on one side of each panel, the actual move on the other, so the connection is visible.

The Mango Lab Growth Model (Artifact 7)

Most decks I have read kind of skip the part where they walk you through how the company actually grows from one stage to the next, and I wanted that part written down properly. Four stages, each with a trigger that unlocks the next one. The flywheel that connects them.

Both extras came from the same place, basically. I did not want this document to be a list of frameworks I read about in books. I wanted it to be a record of how those frameworks actually shaped a company that exists, with real clients, real numbers, and real people running it And this was my first time really trying it so it is also for me to remember and improve how to do it better the next time.

Assessment Grading

Your final grade will be calculated based on the quality and thoughtfulness of your written responses and the clarity and professionalism of your submitted artifacts.

Component	Points
Part 1: **The Founder's Mindset** (Questions 2-3)	5
Part 2: **The Venture** (Questions 4-9)	15
Part 3: **The Offering** (Questions 10-13)	15
Part 4: **The Journey & Reflection** (Questions 14-19)	15
Challenge Reflections (All 4 combined)	10
Artifacts (All 5 combined)	40
Total	**100**